Disclosure without Engagement

An empirical review of positionality statements at FAccT from 2018-2024, examining how researchers disclose identity and background—and whether they connect these features to impacts on their work.

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RESEARCH CONTEXT

The Rise of Positionality Statements

In 2024, FAccT Program Chairs recommended authors include positionality statements—dramatically increasing their use. These statements, originating from anthropology, ask researchers to reflect on how their backgrounds shape their work.

Despite growing popularity, the practice remains controversial. Critics worry about undermining anonymous peer review, while others fear vulnerable researchers face additional risks through disclosure.

82

Total Statements

Positionality statements found across all FAccT years

65

In 2024 Alone

Statements after PC recommendation

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

What We Investigated

01

Frequency

How often do authors include positionality statements in their papers?

02

Content

Which facets of identity and background do authors highlight?

03

Connection

How often do they relate these features to impacts on their research?

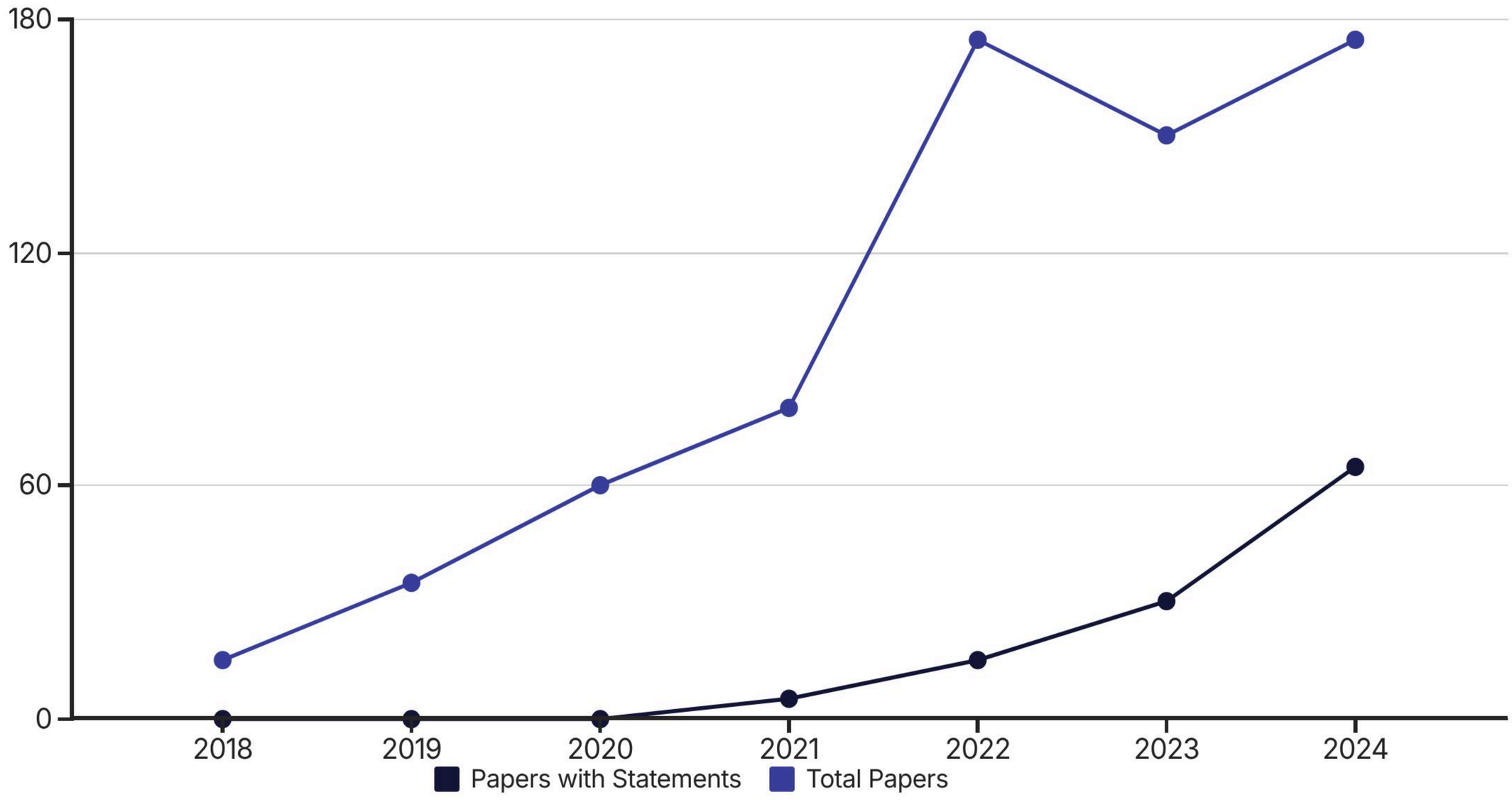
04

Impact Types

What specific ways do authors see their positionality impacting their work?

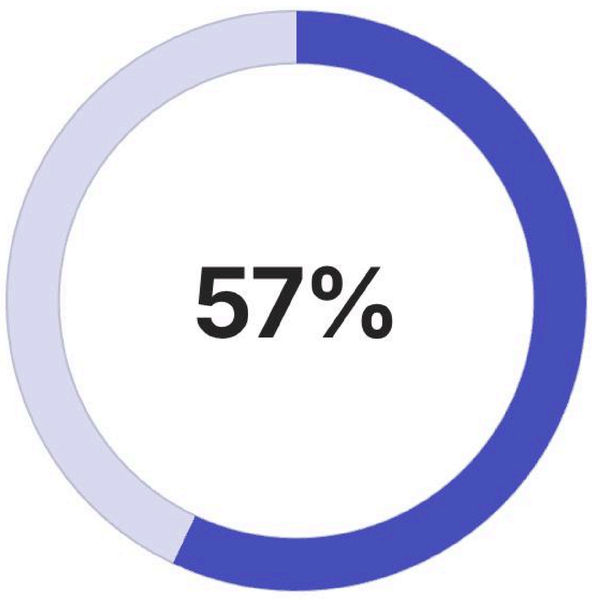
Dramatic Growth in 2024

The 2024 recommendation transformed positionality statement adoption at FAccT. While earlier years saw minimal use, 2024 marked a watershed moment with 65 statements—representing 35% of all papers.



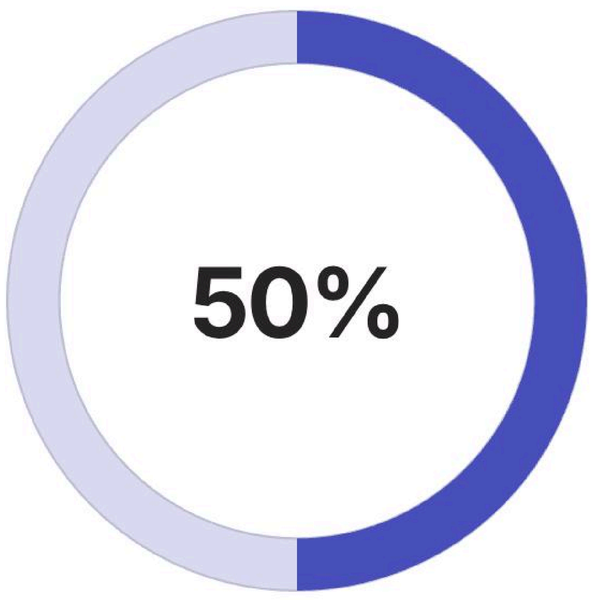
KEY FINDING

What Researchers Disclose



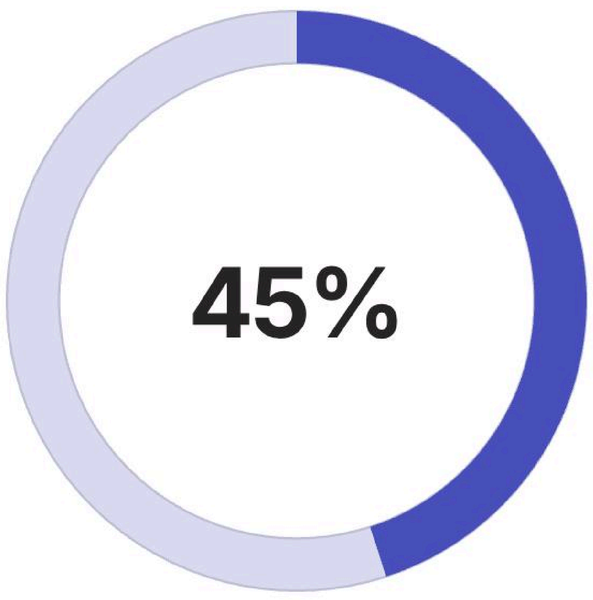
Training & Background

Most commonly disclosed feature



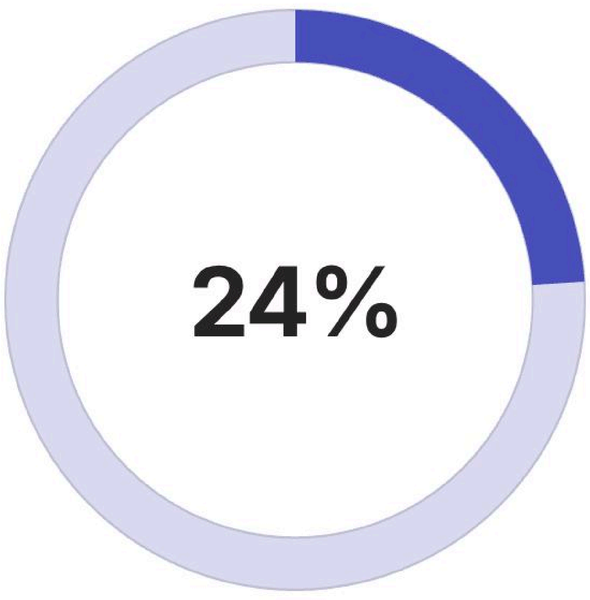
Personal Geography

Place of birth, residence, or education



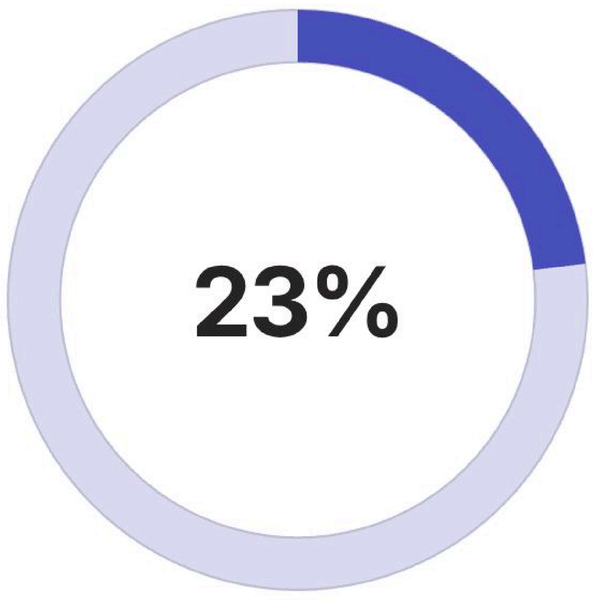
Subject Relationship

Personal or professional connection



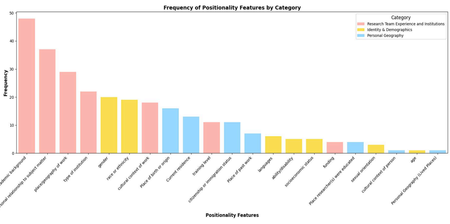
Gender

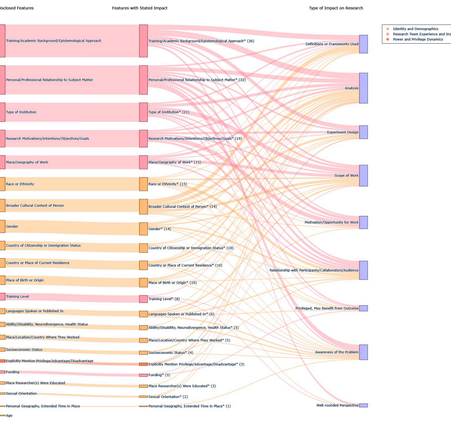
Identity disclosure



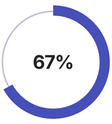
Race/Ethnicity

Identity disclosure





The Critical Gap: Disclosure Without Engagement



Connect to Impact

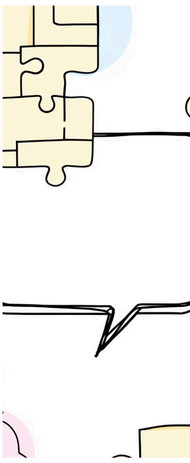
Statements linking positionality to research impact

A full third of positionality statements disclose features without explaining their impact on the work. This creates a vacuum where readers may rely on stereotypes to interpret how disclosed characteristics influenced research decisions.

Example: "The author is white, uses he/him pronouns, and is based in Europe" with no discussion of how this shaped the research.

Disclose Only

Statements with no discussion of impact



CRITICAL ANALYSIS

Types of Research Impact Described

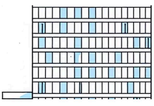
When authors do connect positionality to impact, they describe diverse influences on their work:

Scope & Definitions
33 statements
How background shaped research questions and conceptual frameworks

Analysis
18 statements
Influence on data interpretation and findings

Awareness
11 statements
Lived experience sensitizing researchers to problems

Participant Relations
9 statements
How identity affected trust and information sharing



The Industry Influence Blind Spot

20%

Industry Papers

Statements from papers with industry-affiliated authors

25%

Engaged

Of those that discussed industry influence

Despite ongoing debates about industry's influence on FAccT research, **only 4 of 16 industry-affiliated papers meaningfully engaged with how their corporate context shaped the work.**

This suggests researchers overlook salient factors when left to decide which features to disclose—potentially distracting from influences more significant than individual identity characteristics.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Moving Forward: Three Key Recommendations

Revitalize CRAFT Sessions

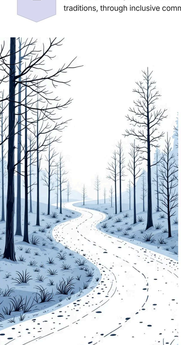
Use the Critiquing and Rethinking Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency track to teach reflexivity practices, especially for researchers from fields where it's not the norm.

Evaluate Interventions Empirically

Continue studying the effectiveness of positionality statements and other reflexivity mechanisms through rigorous research.

Clarify Conference Policies

Develop precise guidelines that balance protecting vulnerable researchers with supporting those from reflexive traditions, through inclusive community input.



Conclusion: The Path to Meaningful Reflexivity

Positionality statements can provide valuable insights when authors meaningfully connect disclosed features to research impacts. However, **disclosure without engagement may do more harm than good**—encouraging essentialist thinking and failing to foster reflexivity throughout the research process.

The decision to include positionality statements should flow from disciplinary training and methodological needs, not conference pressure. Long-term success requires teaching researchers how to engage in reflexivity, not just telling them to do it.

> "Reflexivity requires effort, and crafting thoughtful positionality statements is—and should be—hard. The question is what hopes we should pin on a practice with such inherent challenges."